

How KIIT and KISS Became Sports Powerhouses

KIIT - Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology and KISS- Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences, Odisha, India, are the two names synonymous with excellence in sports, and have developed a model of sporting excellence that has become an example for other universities to learn, follow, and implement. With the success of the kind that KIIT and KISS have seen in terms of sports, one would assume that the Founder of these institutions either came from a rich pedigree or was a sportsperson. It is hard to believe that this model has been ideated, created, curated, and catalyzed by a person who was born in poverty, raised in poverty by his widowed mother with seven siblings, losing his father at the age of four in the remote village of Kalarabanka in Odisha in the 1970s. Sports was never in his remotest thoughts.

➤ The same person grew up to start two educational institutions, KIIT and KISS,

at the age of 25 with just 100 US dollars at that time in 1992-93. He has always focussed on creation of sports infrastructure since its inception. KIIT and KISS together have 17 sports complexes, Olympic-size swimming pools, an athletics stadium, archery grounds, a cricket stadium, rugby and hockey stadiums named after legends, and India's first and only velodrome within a university campus. These facilities are complemented by a 2600-bed hospital, ensuring world-class medical support for athletes, training in the campus or coming to play. However, just the infrastructure doesn't guarantee

success. KIIT and KISS nurture sports talent by providing free education, training, scholarships, and international exposure. Many athletes are identified at a young age, provided with rigorous training, and given academic support to ensure holistic development. Over 5000 sportspersons have been nurtured at KISS, with 1500 competing at national and international levels across 32 sporting disciplines. The vision for the 2028 Olympics and beyond is ambitious yet attainable, with 10-15 students from KISS anticipated to compete, reinforcing its reputation as a cradle for future champions.

